OCR GCSE Geography B (J384) — Paper 3: Geographical Exploration · and fieldwork in Papers 1 and 2

3.1 Geographical Exploration and Fieldwork

1. How OCR B Assesses Fieldwork and Geographical Exploration

Paper	Fieldwork / exploration content
Paper 1: Our Natural World (1h15, 70 marks)	Includes questions on your **physical** geography fieldwork and on unfamiliar physical fieldwork contexts
Paper 2: People and Society (1h15, 70 marks)	Includes questions on your **human** geography fieldwork and on unfamiliar human fieldwork contexts
Paper 3: Geographical Exploration (1h30, 60 marks)	A synoptic paper based on a **resource booklet given out in the exam**, usually about a particular country. It draws on content from across the course and ends with a decision-making question.

- You must carry out **at least two fieldwork enquiries** in contrasting environments — one physical and one human — and show an understanding of how physical and human geography interact.
- Paper 3 rewards **synoptic** thinking: linking, for example, a country's development to its hazards, climate, ecosystems and resources.

Exam Tip: In Paper 3 there is no pre-release, so practise reading unfamiliar resources quickly. Use the figures as evidence, link them to topics you have studied, and in the final decision question make a clear, justified choice that considers different stakeholders and the social, economic and environmental impacts.

2. The Six Stages of a Geographical Enquiry

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Stage	What you need to know
1. Suitable question	Formulate an enquiry question or hypothesis that can be investigated through fieldwork. Know the geographical theory or concept behind it (e.g. the Bradshaw model for rivers) and why the location was suitable (safe, accessible, shows the feature being studied).
2. Selecting, measuring and recording data	Primary data (collected yourself) and secondary data (collected by others, e.g. census data, Environment Agency flood data, maps). Sampling methods: **random**, **systematic** (at regular intervals) and **stratified** (in proportion to sub-groups). Know the equipment used and how to reduce risks.
3. Processing and presenting data	Choose suitable methods — line graphs, bar charts, pie charts, scatter graphs, cross-sections, choropleth maps, annotated photographs, flow-line maps. Justify why each was appropriate.
4. Describing, analysing and explaining	Describe patterns and trends, identify anomalies, use statistics (mean, median, mode, range, interquartile range) and explain the results using geographical theory.
5. Reaching conclusions	Answer the original question or say whether the hypothesis was proved, supported by evidence.
6. Evaluation	Identify problems with data collection (accuracy, reliability, sample size, weather, human error), limitations of the methods and conclusions, and suggest improvements and extensions.

3. Example Physical Enquiry: River Characteristics Downstream

Hypothesis: "Channel width, depth and velocity increase with distance downstream."

- **Theory:** the **Bradshaw model** predicts that width, depth, discharge and velocity increase downstream, while gradient and load particle size decrease.
- **Method:** systematic sampling at several sites along the river. Width measured with a tape measure; depth with a metre rule at regular intervals across the channel; velocity by timing a

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float over 10 m (repeated three times and averaged); pebble size with a ruler or callipers (10 pebbles per site, chosen randomly).

- **Presentation:** cross-sections for each site; scatter graphs of distance downstream against width, depth and velocity, with a line of best fit.
- **Risks:** drowning, slipping, cold water, waterborne disease (Weil's disease) — reduced by wearing wellingtons, working in groups, avoiding high-flow conditions and washing hands.
- **Evaluation:** only a few sites were sampled; a single visit means results reflect that day's flow; floats can get stuck; human error reading measurements. Improvements: more sites, using a flow meter, repeating on several dates.

4. Example Human Enquiry: Quality of Life Across a City

Question: "How and why does the quality of the environment vary from the inner city to the suburbs?"

- **Theory:** urban land-use models (e.g. the Burgess concentric zone model) and the idea of inequality within cities.
- **Method:** a transect from the city centre outwards with systematic sampling every 500 m. At each site: an environmental quality survey (bipolar scoring of litter, graffiti, green space, building condition), pedestrian or traffic counts, noise readings, questionnaires using random or stratified sampling. Secondary data: Index of Multiple Deprivation, census data and house prices.
- **Presentation:** line graphs of score against distance; choropleth maps of deprivation; radar charts comparing sites; annotated photographs.
- **Evaluation:** environmental quality surveys are subjective (different students score differently); a small number of questionnaires may not be representative; time of day affects pedestrian counts. Improvements: group scoring with agreed criteria, larger samples and repeat visits.

5. Geographical Skills

Skills can be tested in all three papers. Make sure you can:

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- **Cartographic:** use four- and six-figure grid references, scale and distance, compass directions, contour lines and spot heights on OS maps; describe and explain patterns on atlas and choropleth maps; interpret cross-sections and transects.
- **Graphical:** construct and interpret line graphs, bar charts, pie charts, scatter graphs (with lines of best fit), population pyramids, climate graphs, triangular graphs and dispersion diagrams.
- **Numerical and statistical:** calculate percentages, percentage change, mean, median, mode, range, quartiles and interquartile range; understand correlation and the difference between correlation and causation.
- **Formulating enquiry:** identify questions, sequence investigations and evaluate sources.
- **Literacy:** write extended answers using specialist terms accurately — SPaG marks are awarded on selected questions in every paper.

> **Exam Tip:** In fieldwork questions on your own enquiry, always name your location and give specific details (e.g. "we measured at 6 sites along Carding Mill Valley, 200 m apart"). Generic answers that could apply to anyone's fieldwork are capped at the lower levels.

6. How to Approach the Resource Booklet

1. Spend a few minutes skimming the whole booklet before answering — understand the place, the issue and the options.
2. Annotate figures as you go: what does each show, and does it support or oppose any option?
3. Identify the **stakeholders** and their likely views.
4. Use both the resources *and* your own knowledge from across the whole course — hazards, climate, ecosystems, development, urban and resource topics.

7. Making and Justifying the Decision

- Choose **one** option and state it clearly at the start.
- Justify it using evidence from several figures — quote data and refer to figure numbers.
- Consider **economic, social and environmental** impacts, in the **short and long term**, and for **different stakeholders**.

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- Explain why you rejected the other options.
- Acknowledge the weaknesses of your chosen option and suggest how they could be reduced.
- Link to **sustainability** — does the option meet present needs without harming future generations?

8. Useful Frameworks

Framework	Use
SEE / SEEP	Social, Economic, Environmental (and Political) impacts
Futures wheel	Map out the knock-on effects of a decision
Cost–benefit analysis	Weigh up gains and losses of each option
Stakeholder conflict matrix	Show which groups agree and disagree

Exam Tip: The highest marks go to answers that are *balanced but decisive*: they recognise that every option has drawbacks, but still reach a clear, well-supported judgement. Leave time to check spelling, punctuation and grammar — SPaG marks are awarded on the extended questions.

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